



Goswami said, explaining her side's 'why fix what isn't broken' approach.

UP Warriorz was among the top spenders this time, splashing out ₹14.15 crore in rebuilding its squad. The WPL borrowed from the IPL in allowing teams the Right to Match option for the first time — a provision that allows a team to retain a player by matching the highest bid made for them by another franchise. The Warriorz used their RTM cards to piece its core back together, alongside making smart purchases to assemble what appears to be the strongest unit on paper ahead of the new season, which gets underway in January.

"Sometimes you want the market to decide the value of a player, and

for us, we felt we wanted to come into the auction with the option of having money. I think when you sit in any auction, you want to start with having a lot of money, and if you look at it, we saved ₹30 lakh, so every money saved is money earned," new UP Warriorz coach Abhishek Nayar told reporters after the auction.

That pesky thing called the 'market' played quite a bit of havoc with pre-auction predictions. Australian keeper-batter Alyssa Healy going unsold stunned one and all, while Sophie Ecclestone — earlier acquired by UP Warriorz for ₹1.8 crore — was brought back to her old side for just ₹85 lakh. Nayar expected the tussle for her to be worth at least ₹1.5 crore.

A ₹15 crore purse is a luxury and a restriction in equal measure. Teams need to guard against spending too much too soon, but also need to plan and back their bids for star players who can often define the character of a side. In the eight-player marquee set that kicked off the auction, bids were conservative for the likes of Ecclestone and Renuka Singh, who drew only ₹60 lakh, eventually going to the Giants. Specialist batters in imperious form — such as Meg Lanning and Laura Wolvaardt (first roped in by Gujarat Giants as an injury replacement for Beth Mooney in the first season) — drew big bucks: ₹1.90 crore (a jump from the ₹1.10 crore she got in 2023) and ₹1.10 crore, respectively. These